with the other directors. He also added that in any case, he did not have the authority to take a decision on Mody's request.

Despite the unpleasant breakfast meeting, on his return, Ratan sent Mody a very warm handwritten letter. He wrote: 'Your good wishes and, above all, your friendship means a great deal to me. I have valued this over the years and look forward to its continuance in the coming years. With affectionate regards and best wishes for 1989.' The communication was completely silent on Mody's request and the unpleasantness that had characterized their meeting in Jamshedpur. It was a typical Ratan response —displaying grace under stress.

There was, however, no let-up in Mody's effort to climb to the apex of the Tata pyramid. He subtly probed whether Ratan was in the race to succeed JRD on his retirement. Less than a month after Ratan's appointment as chairman, TELCO, Mody faxed him an article published in a leading newspaper, with a covering note, hoping to get a response from him. The article titled 'Bombay House brew' had appeared just a week after Ratan's appointment.

The article concluded with a comment that after Ratan's current appointment, 'only the final succession issue remains to be sorted out in Bombay House: who will succeed J.R.D. Tata?' The young Tata did not oblige Mody with a reply, but it was clear who would succeed JRD. The TELCO episode had cleared the decks for Ratan to take over when JRD relinquished charge. But it had wounded the giant of the largest industrial group in the country, whom nobody took lightly.

Mody's Diatribe

Mody was upset at Ratan's appointment as chairman, TELCO. He bewailed that he was betrayed. He blew hot against JRD who, he said, had not kept his word.

Mody soured his relations with Ratan too. He told his biographers: 'What I felt bad about was that Ratan, JRD, and myself had all been party to a decision on the TELCO chairmanship…. But firstly, I think an attempt should have been made to persuade him [Moolgaokar] that it was not my fault. And secondly, I was surprised by the alacrity with which Ratan accepted the chairmanship.'